

Question the sources

Read the following extracts and answer the questions.

Source 1—Plutarch, *Life of Alexander*, 32

Parmenio entered Alexander's tent, stood by his couch and called him several times; when Alexander woke, Parmenio asked how he could possibly sleep as if he were already victorious, instead of being out to fight the greatest battle of his life. Alexander smiled and said, 'Why not? Do you not see that we have already won the battle, now that we are delivered from roving around these endless devastated plains, and chasing Darius, who will never stand and fight?' And indeed, not only beforehand, but at the very height of the battle Alexander displayed the supremacy

and steadfastness of a man who is confident of the soundness of his judgment.

Source 2—Arrian, *The Campaigns of Alexander*, 7.5

He had tables set up in the army quarters with money on them, and instructed the clerks in charge to pay off the debts of every man who produced an IOU... This gift to his men is said to have been worth 20 000 talents. He also made a number of other money awards for distinguished conduct in the field, or in recognition of a man's reputation for good service generally.

Source 3—Arrian, *The Campaigns of Alexander*, 6.26

Alexander, like everyone else, was tormented by thirst, but he was none the

less marching on foot at the head of his men... As they toiled on, a party of light infantry which had gone off looking for water found some... They scooped up with difficulty what they could and hurried back... to Alexander; then... gave it to him. Alexander, with a word of thanks... in full view of his troops, poured the water onto the ground. So extraordinary was the effect of this action that the water wasted by Alexander was as good as a drink for every man in the army.

- List the methods mentioned by each source that Alexander used to gain the respect of his troops.
- Why was it important for Alexander to be popular with his troops?

Research activity

Read Plutarch's *Life of Alexander* and Arrian's *The Campaigns of Alexander* and then answer these questions.

- Using both sources, describe the events of 325BC at the River Hyphasis in India.
- Using both sources, describe the events of 324BC at Opis.
- What reasons are given as the causes of each of these events?
- How did Alexander deal with them?
- What picture do we get of Darius from Arrian? What prejudices would Arrian have?
- To what extent do you think Alexander's victories over Darius were simply the result of superior military training, experience and weaponry?
- Was Alexander a great general and military leader?

word and his bond were inviolable. Spending but little on his own pleasures, he poured out his money without stint for the benefit of his friends.

THE CAMPAIGNS OF ALEXANDER, 7.29

Exhaustion in the army?

At first Alexander maintained the loyalty of his troops. But during the campaign his army mutinied twice: at the Hyphasis River in India in 325BC and again at Opis in 324BC.

Alexander, with little danger to himself, rallied the army. His troops were tired and a long way from home; some had not seen Macedonia in nearly ten years. Apart from these two incidents they followed him everywhere and endured great hardships.

Other factors

Darius' poor generalship

Despite the vast resources available to him, both in numbers of men and monetary terms, Darius' constant poor judgment (or advice) put him at a disadvantage. Darius was certainly no match militarily for the boldness and genius of Alexander. Arrian

describes Darius at Issus:

First one, then another [adviser] blew up the bladder of [Darius'] conceit by saying that the Persian cavalry would ride over the Macedonian army and trample it to pieces ... [this] led Darius to take up a position where he could get little advantage either from his cavalry or his superiority in numbers of men and weight of missiles—a position where he had no chance of dazzling [the Macedonians] with the splendour of his great host, but was doomed to make a present of easy victory to Alexander and the Macedonians.

THE CAMPAIGNS OF ALEXANDER, 3.6-7

Macedonian army vs. Persian army

Alexander could not have conquered the Persian Empire without the highly trained and efficient army left to him by his father Philip. Arrian (1.15) tells us that at the Battle of Granicus:

Things soon turned in favour of Alexander's men; their experience and the weight of their attack began to tell, added to the advantage of the long cornel-wood spear [sarissa] over the light lances of the Persians.